

LUCÍA CONTRERAS

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PLACEMENT CONTACT

Placement Director: David Delacretaz
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RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Finance, Corporate Taxation, Development Economics

REFERENCES

Mazhar Waseem
Professor of Economics
University of Manchester
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James Banks
Professor of Economics
University of Manchester
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Rachel Griffith
Professor of Economics
University of Manchester
rachel.griffith@manchester.ac.uk

EDUCATION

2027 (expected)	PhD Economics , University of Manchester, UK <i>PhD Intern</i> , Centre for Tax Policy and Administration, OECD (2025) <i>PhD Enrichment Scholar</i> , TaxDev, Institute for Fiscal Studies (2024)
2018	MSc Economics (with Distinction), University of Sussex, UK
2014	BSc Economics , Universidad de Costa Rica, Costa Rica

JOB MARKET PAPER

Less Simple, Less Distortionary? Evidence from Costa Rica's Corporate Tax Reform
with Jonathan Garita

We study firms' responses to Costa Rica's 2019 CIT reform, which replaced a notched schedule with a kinked one, reducing distortions in the system at the cost of simplicity. Using 2016–2023 administrative returns in a difference-in-differences design that exploits rich variation in marginal and average rates, we find: (i) signs of tax manipulation, such as bunching and profit-margin discontinuities at the first (now eliminated) revenue threshold, declined promptly after the reform; (ii) responses were asymmetric, with reactions to tax increases weaker than those to tax cuts, likely due to the removal of growth barriers; (iii) firms behaved like profit maximisers: their profits and other intensive-margin variables responded to marginal but not average tax rates, in contrast with evidence that individuals, when confronted with relatively complex non-linear schedules, conflate the two rates and deviate from optimising behaviour. Overall, clear communication of complex reforms from policymakers can improve efficiency without leading to increased compliance errors.

WORKING PAPERS

Multinational Responses to Coordinated Tax Reform: Evidence from the Global Minimum Tax
with Felix Hugger and Tom Zawisza | OECD Taxation Working Paper No. 77

This paper studies how multinational enterprises (MNEs) respond to a coordinated change in corporate taxation. It analyses the introduction of the Global Minimum Tax (GMT), which in 2024 subjected MNEs with revenues above EUR 750m to a minimum effective rate of 15%. Exploiting this revenue threshold in a difference-in-differences framework, this paper assesses the impact of the GMT on effective tax rates, investment and employment. Based on group-level Orbis data, the analysis finds that the GMT meaningfully increased effective tax rates of in-scope MNEs, but this increase was not accompanied by a detectable reduction in investment or employment. The increase in effective tax rates is concentrated in MNEs with characteristics associated with greater profit shifting opportunities and higher profitability. The findings provide first ex-post evidence on the effects of the GMT and suggest that internationally coordinated reforms can raise the effective taxation of MNEs without generating short-run reductions in economic activity.

Low-Earning Workers and Social Security: Evidence from Costa Rica's Contributions Reform

with Laura Abramovsky and Jonathan Garita

High social security contribution costs are widely viewed as a key barrier to formal registration, especially for low-earning workers in developing economies. In Costa Rica, the design of the social security system generates particularly high registration costs for low-wage workers and their employers due to a minimum contribution floor. In 2023, a reform sought to reduce these costs by lowering the floor, thereby decreasing contribution burdens for both employers and employees, with a gradual rollout by age. Using rich administrative and survey data and regression discontinuity design exploiting the phased implementation, this paper evaluates the reform's effects on registration and other labour market outcomes six months after it came into force. We find no significant effects on registration or on earnings reported to the social security administration. However, using constructed measures of net and gross earnings, we find higher take-home pay for workers and lower total labour costs for firms, indicating that cost savings were shared in line with the statutory changes. Overall, our short-term results suggest that lowering contribution costs alone may not be sufficient to increase registration and highlight the need for complementary policies to address remaining barriers to formality.

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

2026	Oxford Centre for Business Taxation Doctoral Conference; Mannheim Taxation Conference
2025	ZEW Public Finance Conference; Royal Economic Society; International Institute of Public Finance Conference; OECD Tax Policy and Statistics Division; OECD Working Party 2 on Tax Policy Analysis and Tax Statistics
2024	Royal Economic Society PhD Conference; The Economics of Informality (Universidad de los Andes); Programa Estado de la Nación; Universidad de Costa Rica; Institute for Fiscal Studies
2023	Economists Conference of Costa Rica; North West Social Science Doctoral Training Partnership Conference
2015–2021	Commission of Coastal and Border Zones, Costa Rican Congress (2021); Western Economic Association International Conference (2021); Annual Meeting of the Environment for Development Initiative (2020); Costa Rican Presidential National Council for Children (2019); Annual Meeting of the CASCADE Project (2015)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Associate , Department of Economics, University of Manchester Economics for Public Policy (TA Lead), Microeconomics 2 (TA Lead), Microeconomics 1, Microeconomics 3, Advanced Statistics, Applied Economics	<i>2025–present</i>
Graduate Teaching Assistant , Department of Economics, University of Manchester Economics for Public Policy, Microeconomics 2	<i>2022–2025</i>
Lecturer , School of Economics, Universidad de Costa Rica Research Methods (Master's), Introduction to Economics	<i>2017–2021</i>
Graduate Teaching Assistant , Department of Economics, University of Sussex Economic Principles	<i>2018–2019</i>
Teaching Assistant , School of Economics, Universidad de Costa Rica Introduction to Economics	<i>2012</i>

RESEARCH AND POLICY EXPERIENCE

2025–present	Researcher , International Growth Centre, London School of Economics
2019–2021	Researcher , Economic Sciences Research Institute (IICE), Universidad de Costa Rica
2019–2021	Researcher , Tropical Agricultural Research and Higher Education Center (CATIE)
2016–2017	Junior Researcher , Development Observatory, Universidad de Costa Rica
2014–2016	Research Assistant , CATIE

SELECTED POLICY WORK

[Import Tax Evasion, Drivers and Recommendations for Tanzania](#), 2026

International Growth Centre, London School of Economics

[Dynamics and Impacts of the Tax Reform on the Costa Rican Labour Market](#), 2022

with Juan Robalino, Andrés Fiallos and Felipe Carrera / Universidad de Costa Rica

[Potential Effects of Granting Registrable Property Rights over Land in Areas of the State's Natural Heritage](#), 2021

with Juan Robalino / UNDP and Universidad de Costa Rica

[The Effect of Regulation on Fees for the Use of Cards on Consumer Prices](#), 2021

with Juan Robalino, Rudolf Lucke, Luis Oviedo and David Navarro / Universidad de Costa Rica

[Methodological Proposal and Roadmap for Measuring Resources Allocated to Children in Costa Rica](#), 2020

with Juan Robalino and Luis Oviedo / UNICEF, Patronato Nacional de la Infancia and Universidad de Costa Rica

[Economic Impact of the Plastic Tax](#), 2019

with Juan Robalino, Rudolf Lucke and Luis Oviedo / UNDP and Universidad de Costa Rica

PRE-DOCTORAL PUBLICATION

[Climate Change Perceptions and Adaptive Responses of Small-Scale Farmers in Two Guatemalan Landscapes](#), 2019

with Bárbara Viguera, Francisco Alpízar, Celia A. Harvey, M. Ruth Martínez-Rodríguez and Milagro Saborío-Rodríguez
Agronomía Mesoamericana

OTHER PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2013–2014

Economic Analyst, Ecoanálisis Economic and Financial Consultants

Monitored macroeconomic developments; organised seminars on the economic outlook and policy

GRANTS, AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

Economics Tutor Awards (Highly Commended), University of Manchester 2026

Heinz König Award (3rd Prize), ZEW Leibniz Centre for European Economic Research 2025

Small Project Facility Grant (Principal Investigator; £13,930), International Growth Centre, LSE 2025

Royal Economic Society Scholars Fund, Royal Economic Society 2025

PhD Enrichment Scheme Award, Institute for Fiscal Studies 2024

Economics PhD Studentship, University of Manchester 2021

Mentorship Research Support Grant (mentor: J. Robalino; US\$10,600), Universidad de Costa Rica 2020

Chevening Scholarship (MSc studies), Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office, UK 2017

Academic Excellence Scholarship (BSc studies), Universidad de Costa Rica 2010

SERVICE

Organiser, Economics PhD Seminar, University of Manchester 2025–2026

TA Representative, Department of Economics, University of Manchester 2024–2025

Residential Life Advisor, Directorate for the Student Experience, University of Manchester 2022–present

SKILLS

Programming Stata (proficient), R, Python, Matlab, ArcGIS (intermediate)

Languages Spanish (native), English (fluent), French (advanced)